

Distribution, Not Product, Separates Startups That Earn From Startups That Don't

An evidence review of 1,000 verified-revenue startups

Headline finding

Top-earning founders hold **8.75x** the domain authority of low earners — but only **4.1x** the audience.

Being findable predicts revenue; having an audience does not

01

Building is no longer the constraint

AI tooling has collapsed the cost of shipping software. The dataset's bottleneck is monetisation, not construction: median monthly revenue across 1,000 verified startups is \$282.

02

Domain authority tracks revenue at every level

Median MRR climbs monotonically across domain-authority bands — \$9 to \$23,536 — and the top band holds 4% of companies but 63% of all 30-day revenue.

03

Audience size does not separate the cohorts

31.6% of founders earning \$10K+/month have zero X followers, versus 30.6% of those under \$1K. The distribution of followers is effectively identical across outcomes.

04

The implication is a curriculum, not a slogan

Discoverability is learnable and currently untaught. Reallocating founder effort from audience-building to findability is the single actionable move this data supports.

SO WHAT Treat distribution as a core competency to be trained, not a personality trait founders either have or lack.

We tested four candidate distribution levers against verified revenue

Domain authority

Backlink-strength score, 0–100.
Proxy for search discoverability.

n = 714

Audience size

Founder X follower count at time
of snapshot.

n = 984

Site traffic

Unique visitors in trailing 30 days.

n = 178

Market breadth

Count of geographic markets a
startup targets.

n = 1,000

Method

- Cohort split at \$10K+/mo (n=212) vs under \$1K/mo (n=591)
- Medians used throughout; revenue is heavily skewed
- Banded analysis to test each relationship across the full range

Known limitations

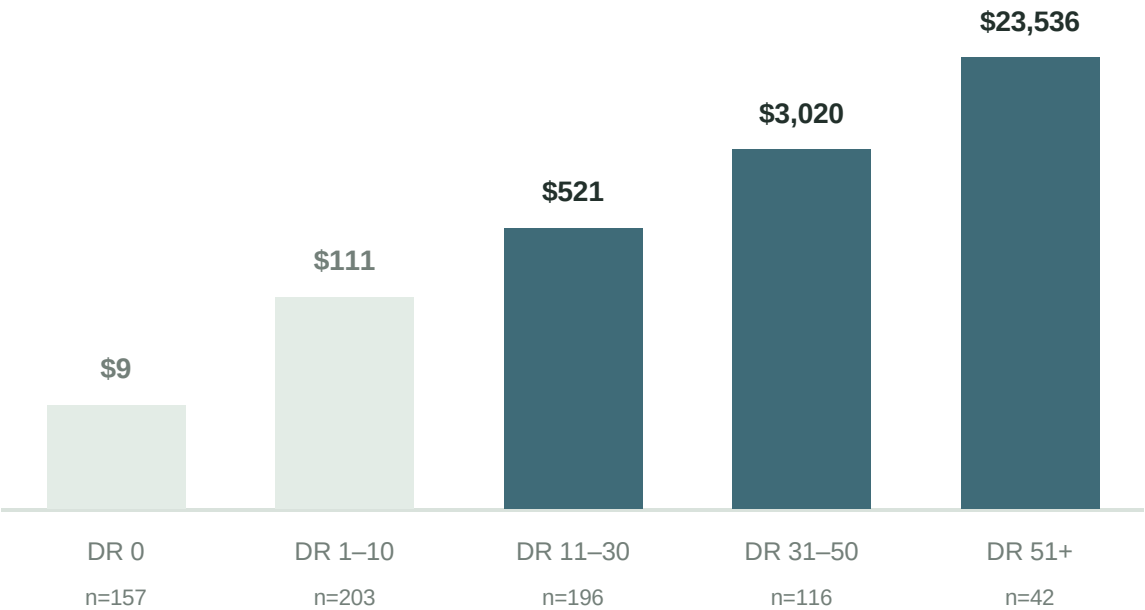
- Self-selected: only founders who expose a payment key
- Single snapshot — no time series, so no causal claims
- Coverage varies; traffic data exists for 178 of 1,000

SO WHAT Findings below are associations measured at a point in time — strong enough to prioritise effort, not to prove causation.

Revenue rises at every step of domain authority — and does not for audience size

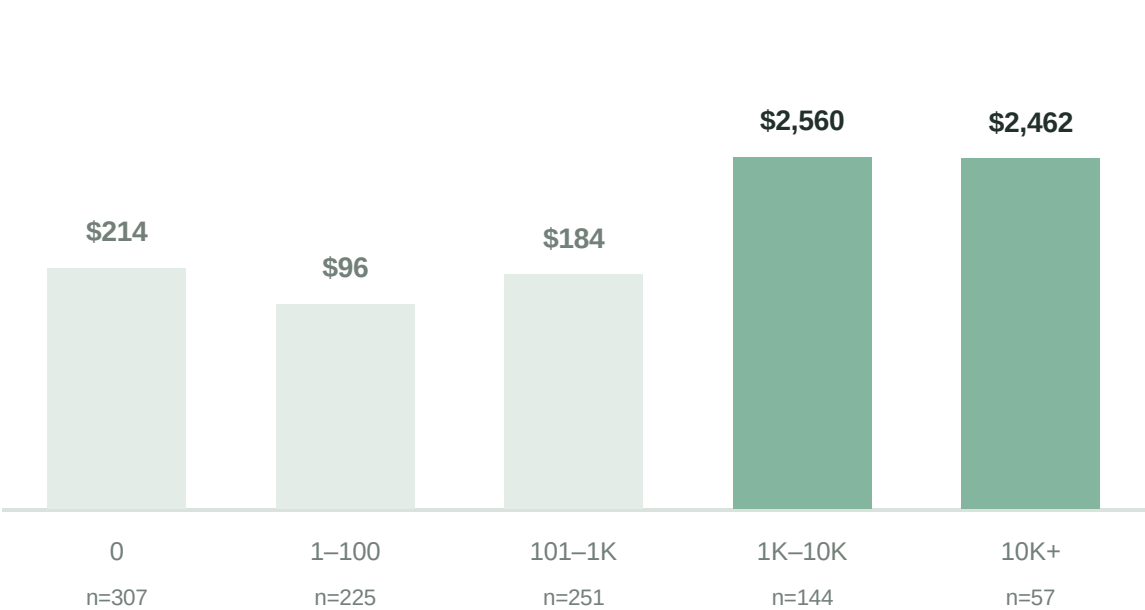
Median MRR by domain-authority band

Monotonic — every band earns more than the one below it. Log scale.



Median MRR by follower band

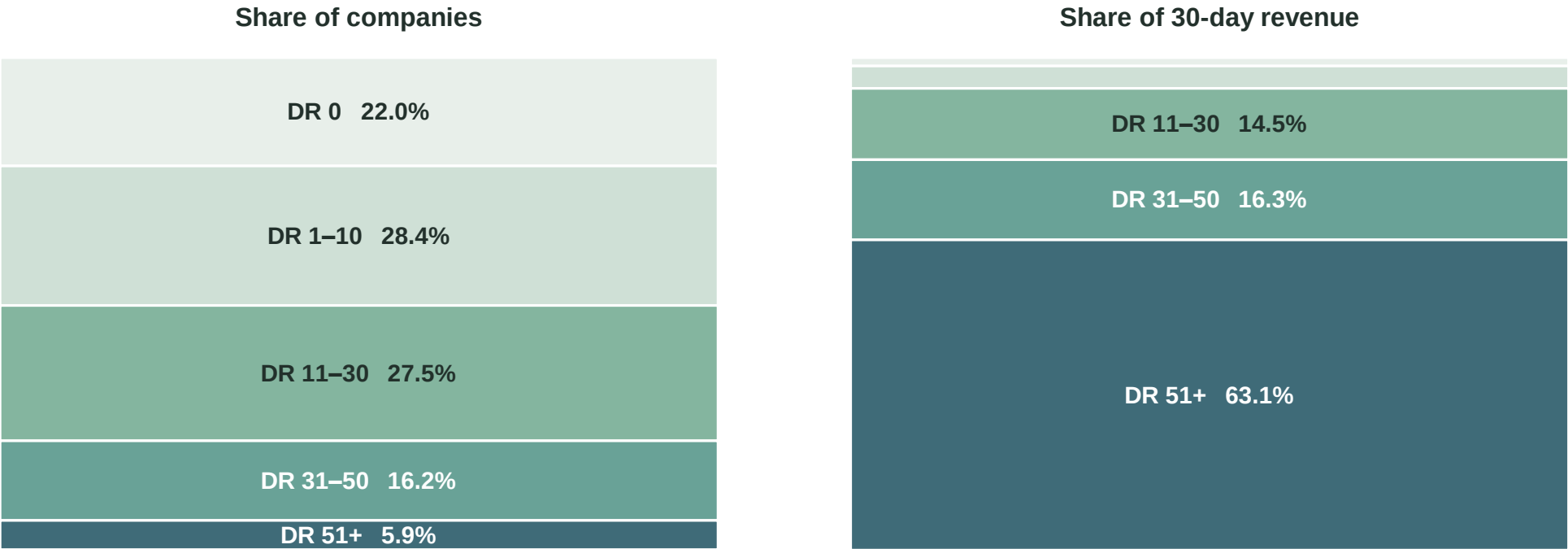
Non-monotonic — falls, recovers, then plateaus. Same log scale.



SO WHAT A founder with zero followers and a strong domain out-earns a founder with 10,000 followers and a weak one.

Source: TrustMRR public dataset, 1,000 verified startups, frozen 30 Jul 2026. Team analysis.

4% of companies hold the strongest domains — and 63% of all revenue



READ ACROSS

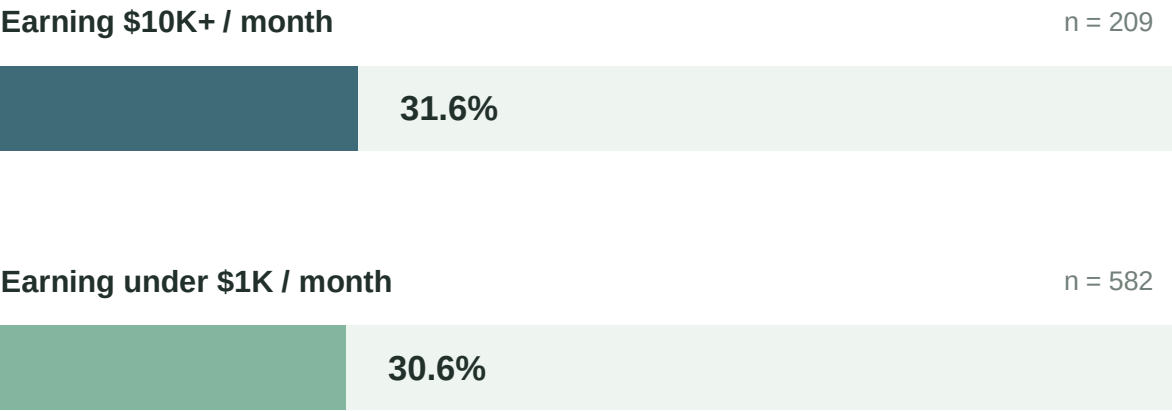
Bands above DR 30 are 22% of companies and 79% of revenue.

SO WHAT Revenue is not merely correlated with findability — it is concentrated almost entirely inside the findable tier.

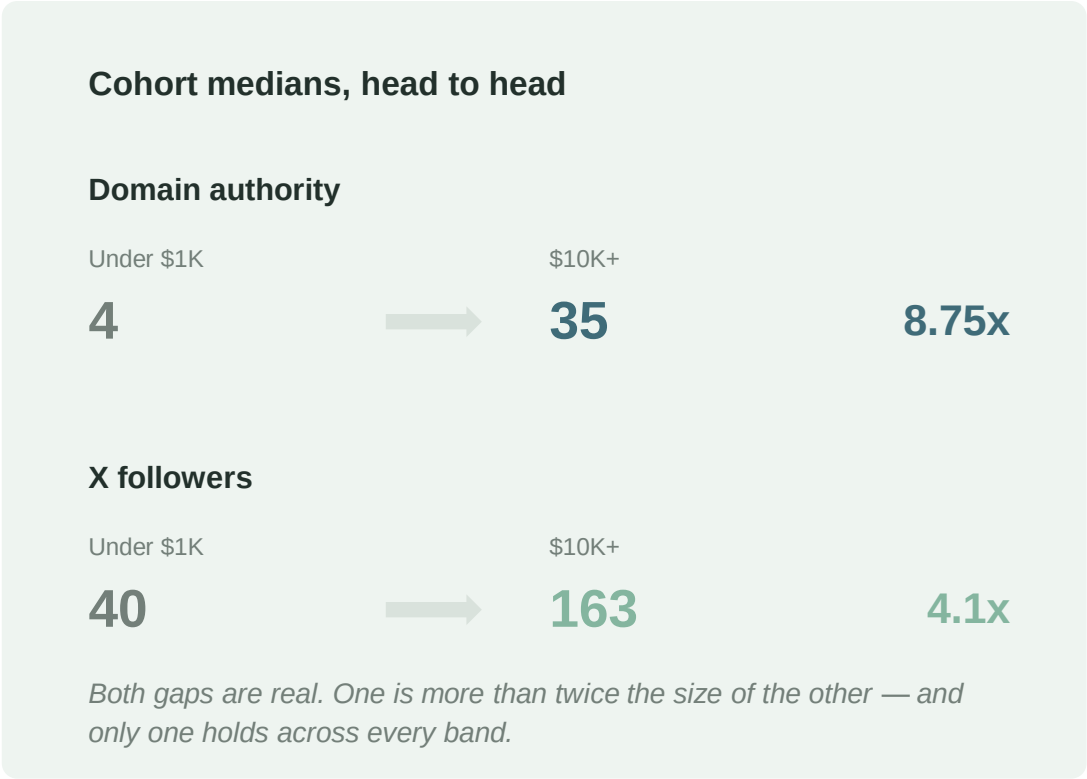
Source: TrustMRR public dataset, 1,000 verified startups, frozen 30 Jul 2026. Team analysis.

Founders with no audience at all are no less likely to be top earners

Share of founders with zero X followers



A one-percentage-point difference between cohorts. Having no audience is as common among the highest earners as among the lowest.



SO WHAT Audience-building is the most visible founder activity and the least associated with revenue in this sample.

Ranking the four levers by strength of evidence, not by intuition

Lever	What the data shows	Evidence strength	Coverage	Verdict
Domain authority	Monotonic across all five bands; \$9 to \$23,536	Strong	714 of 1,000	Teach first
Site traffic	Strongest single association in the dataset	Strong, thin base	178 of 1,000	Teach, flag caveat
Audience size	Non-monotonic; zero-follower rate identical across cohorts	Weak	984 of 1,000	De-prioritise
Market breadth	Median of 3 markets in both cohorts — no separation	None detected	1,000 of 1,000	Ignore

SO WHAT Two levers earn a place in a curriculum. Two do not — including the one founders spend the most time on.

Separating what the data establishes from what it merely suggests

ESTABLISHED BY THE DATA

- Domain authority and revenue rise together across the full range, not only at the extremes
- Revenue is concentrated in the highest-authority tier: 4% of companies, 63% of revenue
- Follower count does not distinguish high earners from low earners in this sample
- Targeting more markets shows no association with higher revenue

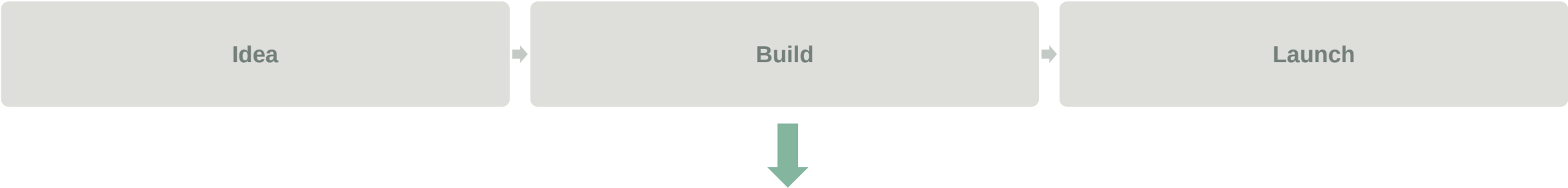
NOT ESTABLISHED — ARGUED

- That distribution causes revenue. Established companies accumulate authority and revenue together; a snapshot cannot separate the two
- That distribution compounds over time. The dataset has no time series, so no feedback loop can be observed
- That product quality does not matter. Product quality is not measured in this dataset at all
- That these findings generalise beyond founders willing to publish verified revenue

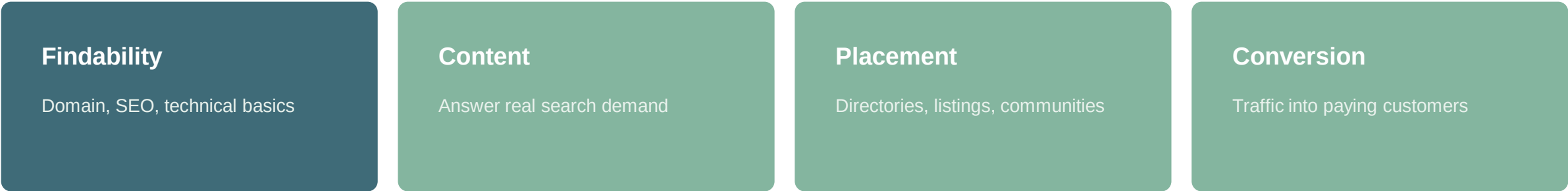
SO WHAT The recommendation stands on the left column alone; the right column is the argument built on top of it.

The founder operating model ends where the evidence says the work begins

Where founder effort typically stops



Where the revenue difference is actually made



SO WHAT Every stage below the arrow is teachable, measurable, and absent from how most founders currently allocate time.

Three moves the evidence supports

01

Make findability the first module, not the last

Domain authority is the only lever that holds across every revenue band. It is also the one most founders address after launch, if at all.

Evidence: Exhibit 1, Exhibit 2

02

Stop treating audience-building as the growth path

Nearly a third of top earners have no audience whatsoever. Effort spent on follower growth is not what distinguishes them.

Evidence: Exhibit 3

03

Measure discoverability the way revenue is measured

Domain authority, traffic and conversion are observable weekly. Make them the tracked metrics rather than downstream revenue alone.

Evidence: Exhibit 4

SO WHAT None of this requires a new thesis — only a reallocation of where founder effort is spent first.

When everyone can build, the advantage moves to being found.

Distribution is the variable this dataset can measure, and the one founders are least likely to be training for.